

Item #40427

Atrosil Hall

The only remaining private estate on international grounds. Above an extensive tunnel network leading to several underground storehouses (est. 148). At present well-maintained and fashioned in a cursory style. Notably used to hold the decennial World's Auction. Seating capacity of 230,000.

Minimum Bid: \$200,000,000,000

Value: N/A

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Phil was being faced with three decisions to be made, each of varying urgency. First: whether to put on his left shoe before his right, or vice versa. Mundane, but pressing by nature—the next decision was located out-of-doors, and he would be neglecting it with every moment of further deliberation.

Second: whether he would go to work today, or duck out to meet with his friend from high school, from whom he'd just received a message, during breakfast, for the first time since graduation. Skewed at face value, but the risk Phil saw was rather high; he'd been scammed before, and had lost his third and fourth most prized possessions because of it.

And third: regardless of how he went about his day—whether it was a touching reunion, a spiteful one, a normal day at the office, or being hustled in an alleyway—whether it (the day) would end up “worth it”. The weight is indeterminate.

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Item #35335

2 Minutes of Rain Above the Sea

Cold and refreshing. From a winter 9 years past. Falls at approximately 14° without wind. Not for consumption.

Minimum Bid: \$21.99

Value: \$80

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The World's Auction hadn't been held in nearly a century, and all items that had ever sat on its stage were now priceless memorabilia of the highest order (or more). In fact, even happening upon a catalog—condition and personal connections notwithstanding—could lift the most unfortunate from poverty.

Phil had happened to happen upon one some years ago. From the Auction's ninth holding. Doing well enough, he'd held onto it. And now, hesitating at his doorstep, he did as he always did when he needed to choose: he pulled the catalog from his satchel, and consulted the listings.

From the second Auction onwards, the catalogs had been digitized to accommodate the growing selection of items. The WA's patented device allowed one to easily search the listings,

sort them by any conceivable metric, or randomize them. The result Phil landed on, standing before his shoes and the world at large:

Item #2054

Whiteboard Used to Draft Every World Map

Every officially used world map was replaced by the comprehensive edition released by famed cartographer Is Asa at the end of the last century. Though the original, finalized wood engraving is on permanent exhibit at the International Museum of History, the WA has procured Asa's personal whiteboard, on which the masterwork was planned. Moderately damaged due to land subsidence. Smaller fragments have been bagged for convenience.

Minimum Bid: \$20,540

Value: \$28,000

Phil put the catalog away, leaned to the side, and thought. He'd always wanted to travel more, but could never find a reason. There was still an atlas somewhere in his room, he was sure—from school, but that was besides the point for the moment. It would be in bad shape though, margins overflowing with cramped notes and whirling doodles, traced borders and copied flags. He hadn't drawn in a while. He was right-handed, but didn't know if he was left or right footed. Last week at work he'd been asked to sign some documents, and had dropped his pen, the clip snagging on a tangle of loose ends in his satchel; he'd stretched out his left leg to

retrieve it, used his left foot to roll it back under his desk, within reach. The office building faced north-northwest; his desk just north. He didn't particularly like the cold.

Phil slipped on his left shoe.

He stepped, right foot (now also shoed) first, through the doorway. The sun was still perched on the horizon. Light scattered through his wind chime, mottling his door as if it were underwater. He started down the stairs.

Early mornings were pleasant mid-autumn, so Phil had been walking to work the past couple of weeks. His commute during less temperate weather was much faster, but, maybe because of that, Phil often found himself rushing in parallel—the hustle, of the trains, buses, the people crowding about, sure, but also the wind, the clouds, and the precipitation (if there was any), all got to him, on some level at least. He wasn't actively bothered, he didn't think, but could certainly feel himself less relaxed, less present. What was some mental inertia in the face of, quite literally, everything else? All there was to be done was to take a seat, stare out the window, and, within minutes, arrive at his destination. A clean and efficient routine. Sometimes, though, that speed made it difficult to see past the windows, leaving him just the outline of his reflection for company. All this, and also the simple fact that the extra hour or so of leeway likely made him negligent.

Today Phil stopped at the second intersection on his normal path. His friend—or “friend”—had wanted to meet at a cafe not exactly in the opposite direction to his workplace, but effectively so. The pedestrian light turned red, and he, once again, reached for his catalog:

Item #16019

Willow's Happiest Memories

Harvested from a 44-year-old corkscrew willow upon its death. Its owner (who has chosen to remain anonymous) says they remember planting it themselves, as a child:

"It feels weird, outliving a tree, I mean, even if I knew it could, and would, happen. I never had any pets, so I guess it was sort of like that for me. They really do grow up so fast. We were truly blessed, though, to get 44 whole years. I hope it liked my garden."

52,750 hours total.

Minimum Bid: \$0

Value: \$386.28

Phil blinked. This was a bit on the nose. The light was green. He stepped into the street. To tell the truth, he'd nearly forgotten about this friend, hadn't thought about them in forever until he got that message. They were close as classmates though, close enough at least, and often... Often what? Hung out? Was that all? Had they shared any interests, or just a handful of classes? Friends by proximity are still friends though. Were. Phil mulled over what he would consider his happiest memories: winning ten dollars from a lottery ticket, then finding out his favorite restaurant was having a sale the same day; finally moving into his own apartment; successfully baking lasagna after one, very, very bad failure; crafting a kaleidoscope from stuff he'd picked up off a beach; his parents letting him stay up late to watch the season finale of *The Most Engaging Show Imaginable*; and finding his catalog. High school seemed a void of sorts. Phil

looked up. The sky was clear, wisps of clouds fleeing in his periphery, trailing off into that expansive well of pale-blue curbed only by the sunlight still working its way up past the buildings behind him. The sky was clear, and- one time, he went stargazing with friends, sneaking onto the school's rooftop. He'd brought binoculars, and someone managed to lug a telescope up all those flights of stairs. There were tarps, snacks, a salt lamp. There was more than that. The sky was clear enough to see the moon.

Phil couldn't remember if this friend was there that night; the message that surprised him over breakfast asked simply to "catch up." Having already crossed the street, he continued on. The cafe was around twenty minutes away.

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Item #6301

Elbow Grease

Labor concentrate, useful for all things arduous, any manner of toil. A proprietary recipe of Valiere Jewelers, the buyer will be made to sign a contract prohibiting resale. Instructions detailing safe usage included. 9 ounces.

Minimum Bid: \$2,950

Value: \$5,800

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"Hey, Phil! Long time, huh? Doing alright, staying healthy? Good, good."

His friend had waved him down before he'd even recognized them, sitting outside under an umbrella, coffee in hand. They were smiling with more familiarity than felt possible. Phil approached, gave a slight wave back, and took a careful look around—the cafe seemed busy, though no one else was seated outside, and, barring the coffee, his friend, seemingly, had nothing at all on their person. A pile of empty sugar packets floated about the table in the morning breeze. One found its way over the edge.

“Sit, sit, want anything to drink? No, my treat of course, a thanks for coming out! Yeah, I was just in the area, thought I'd stop by and catch up, you know? What've you been up to?”

Obliging, Phil responded in kind, though he found himself unable to match their brightness. He ordered an iced tea. It appeared before him as if by train, by wind.

“Desk job huh, yeah I could see that... As long as you like it, right? I could never though, haha! How've I been doing? Pretty good, to be honest! But you know me though, been getting banged up here and there. Actually just got a cast off my leg a few days ago! Slipped while hiking, yeah, badly too—the doctors said it'd take *at least* half a year to fully get better and all that, but here I am, just two months later! See, I've been taking this vitamin supplement that's supposed to help regulate all the fluids in your body, right? And it's insane how much better I've been feeling, I swear like my paper cuts are gone within a day now, and biting my cheek doesn't ruin my week anymore! I could put in an order for you if you want, cheaper than that drink! Yeah, no, I get it if it sounds a little shady, but it's *totally* legit, I promise! And it's all-natural too! Backed by science and everything..”

Phil looked down, through his tea, the cup around it, the table beneath both. Better than a mugging, he supposed.

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Item #18235

Spring Cleaning + Rolls

Former hotel manager turned restaurateur Renat Lark offers the full services of him and his team to clean out your place of residence, and provide you a meal afterwards. Despite the listing, you need not wait until spring; Lark will happily accommodate any date, so long as he is notified two days in advance. Similarly, you may request any dishes off the menu he provides, and not just rolls, spring or otherwise. Lark guarantees cleaning to your exact standards, but reserves the right to decide his hours, should it take multiple days.

Minimum Bid: \$108

Value: \$429.99

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Phil slumped into bed. He'd smiled and nodded until his tea ran out, staunchly refused a refill, then excused himself, assuring his "friend" he would stay in touch, would consider the supplements. Escaping onto a train, he'd clocked into work late, apologized for not calling beforehand, assured his supervisor it was a one-off mistake. No one minded. He left a few minutes early, and chose to walk again. It was colder than the morning, and slower, too.

Phil glanced at his clock. Six-forty. The sun was due to set. He turned to his catalog for the third time that day:

Item #12

Glass

Present and future. Just legally.

Minimum Bid: \$14,000,000,000,000

Value: \$30,000,000,000,000

The screen before him glowed. He shifted his gaze up, back towards his clock. He rolled over to face his window, and saw a deep-blue overtaking the sky behind it. He could hear his wind chime sparkling, could imagine the day's last light brushing through.

Phil sat up, then stood, then stretched. He hadn't had dinner yet.

